Reading

It is not always the actual pain or inconvenience caused by physical impairment that troubles the disabled but the attitude of the peoplearound and the sense of alienation which make them suffer.

H59WDP

Read this play by Susan Hill which beautifully, yet, grimly depicts the sad world of the physically challenged.

b. ON THE FACE OF IT (abridged) An old man and a small boy meet in the former's garden. The old man strikes up a friendship with the boy who is very withdrawn and defiant. What is the bond that unites the two?

SCENE ONE



Mr. Lamb's garden [*There is the occasional sound of birdsong and of tree leaves rustling. Derry's footsteps are heard as he walks slowly and tentatively through the long grass. He pauses, then walks on again. He comes around a screen of bushes and Mr. Lamb speaks to him. He is close at hand and Derry is startled.*)

Mr. Lamb: Mind the apples!

Derry: What? Who's that? Who's there?

Mr. Lamb:
Lamb 's my name. Mind the apples. Crab apples those are. Windfalls in the long grass, you could trip.

Derry:
I thought it was empty....an empty house.

Mr. Lamb:
So, it is. Since I'm out here in the garden. It is empty, until I go back inside. In the meantime, I'm out here and likely to stop. A day like this. Beautiful day. Not a day to be indoors.

Derry: [Panic] I've got to go.

Mr. Lamb:
Not on my account. I don't mind who comes into the garden. The gate's always open. Only you climbed the garden wall.

Derry:[*Angry]* You were watching me.

Mr. Lamb:
I saw you. But the gate's open. All welcome. You're welcome. I sit here. I like sitting.

- ✓ Who is Derry?
- ✓ Why does Derry enter Mr. Lamb's garden?
- ✓ What startles Derry as he enters the garden?

Derry:
I'd not come to steal anything. I just.... wanted to come in. Into the garden.

Mr. Lamb: So, you did. Here we are, then.

Derry: You don't know who I am.

Mr. Lamb: A boy. Thirteen or so.

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